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UAE Presidential Court

PRESIDENT RECEIVES RULER OF RAS AL KHAIMAH

President His Highness Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed Al Nahyan received His Highness Sheikh Saud Bin Saqr Al Qasimi, Supreme Council Member and Ruler of Ras Al Khaimah. During the meeting, Their Highnesses exchanged cordial greetings and discussed a number of issues and topics related to the nation and the well-being of its people.

Dubai Digital Twin Platform to drive smart city launched

The platform integrates digital 3D models of more than 195,000 buildings

DUBAI

BY KHITAM AL AMIR
Chief News Editor

Sheikh Hamdan Bin Mohammed Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Crown Prince of Dubai, Deputy Prime Minister and Minister of Defence of the UAE and Chairman of the Executive Council of Dubai, yesterday witnessed the launch of the Dubai Digital Twin Platform during a workshop organised by Dubai Municipality.

Writing on his X account, Sheikh Hamdan said: "I witnessed the launch of the Dubai Digital Twin Platform during a workshop organised by Dubai Municipality. The platform integrates digital 3D models of more than 195,000 buildings, 330,000 public facilities, and

330k

public facilities to have digital 3D models integrated

280k

infrastructure assets to have digital 3D models integrated

280,000 infrastructure assets across the emirate."

The Dubai Crown Prince said the project embodies the vision of His Highness Sheikh Mohammed Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice-President and Prime Minister of the UAE and Ruler of Dubai, to harness advanced technology and data to build a city that is better prepared for the future.

"It supports objectives of the Dubai Economic Agenda, D33, while strengthening the emirate's global competitiveness and leadership in digital transformation. In the race for excellence, leadership will ultimately belong to cities that shape integrated digital ecosystems and embrace artificial intelligence while fostering collaboration between the public and private sectors as well as entrepreneurs," he said.

Digital replica

Through the Dubai Digital Twin Platform, Dubai Municipality continues to harness advanced technologies to build a comprehensive digital replica of the emirate, bringing together spatial and operational data within a single platform.

The project supports smarter urban planning, enhances the efficiency of asset and infrastructure management, and elevates quality of life.

Indian expats hit by passport service chaos

LEGAL BATTLE LEAVES EMBASSY AND CONSULATE TO HANDLE WALK-INS

DUBAI

BY SAJILA SASEENDRAN
Chief Reporter

For the first time in 15 years, hundreds of Indian expats in the UAE queued up without appointments at their embassy and consulate yesterday to submit passport applications in person, a scene unseen since India first outsourced its overseas consular services in 2009.

The Indian Embassy in Abu Dhabi and the Consulate General in Dubai threw open their own premises for walk-in, first-come-first-served consular services between 9am and 12.30pm from yesterday.

This happened after their outsourcing partners BLS International and SGIVS Global shut shop as their contracts ended, and the scheduled launch of the much-awaited unified consular centres, Indian Consular Application Centres (ICACs), by Alhind Tours and Travels LLC on July 1 was delayed. Hundreds of applicants seeking passport, attestation and other consular services turned up at both missions during the limited window, with staff from various departments joined by community volunteers to manage the crowds. Officials continued working till late evening to clear applications received before 12.30pm.

Court fight behind delay

While the temporary arrangement with new rules to avail consular services was announced by the Indian missions late on Wednesday citing administrative reasons, *Gulf News* can reveal that the disruption is rooted in a legal battle in Delhi, not a routine administrative reshuffle.

Alhind had been picked as the single service provider to run the new ICACs from July 1. But two bidders, E Trav Tech and Verasys, moved Delhi High Court seek-



BLS International and SGIVS Global shut shop as their contracts ended and the scheduled launch of the unified consular centres, Indian Consular Application Centres, by Alhind Tours and Travels LLC on July 1 was delayed.

ing detailed break-up of marks awarded during the technical evaluation, along with the reasoning behind their disqualification.

Though the legal fight escalated to the Supreme Court, the apex court on June 24 ordered status quo and asked the Delhi High Court to hear the matter urgently once again. With the Delhi High Court's multiple hearings yet to yield a ruling on interim relief, Alhind remains unable to formally step in, leaving embassy and consulate staff to fill the gap.

Concern over hiked fees

Those queuing yesterday were also among the first to pay India's revised passport fees, effective July 1, with cash the only accepted mode at the missions.

A regular renewal now costs Dh450, up from Dh285, a near 60 per cent jump, the first major revision since 2012. The hike has alarmed low-income workers, who form roughly 60 to 70 per cent of the UAE's 4.5 million-strong Indian community.

Community volunteers have called the hike a shock for blue-collar expats and low-income families, urging concessional rates. They have asked the Ministry of External Affairs to revise the fee and offer a 50 per cent reduction for at least workers holding Emigration Clearance Required passports.

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UAE unveils new CSR strategy, eyes Dh20b

More contribution by country's private sector towards sustainability goals

DUBAI

BY KHITAM AL AMIR
Chief News Editor

The UAE has launched a new strategy that will see greater contribution of the country's private sector towards sustainability-focused goals in the emirates.

Unveiled by Sheikh Mansour Bin Zayed Al Nahyan, Vice-President, Deputy Prime Minister and Chairman of the Presidential Court, the 'UAE Companies for Good 2031 Strategy' targets collections of over Dh20 billion by 2031.

Last year, the UAE recorded Dh3.23 billion in contributions



This approach has significantly increased awareness of corporate social responsibility across society while contributing to the development of a national economy that delivers positive and sustainable impact."

Sheikh Mansour Bin Zayed Al Nahyan

from 191 companies. Sheikh Mansour said corporate social responsibility and sustainable impact were central to the UAE leadership's vision for advancing prosperity, strengthening social cohesion and building a balanced model that combines economic growth with service to the community.

National initiatives

"We have launched numerous national initiatives and projects aimed at advancing corporate social responsibility,

while strengthening strategic partnerships between the government sector, the private sector, academic institutions, companies, and the third sector. This approach has significantly increased awareness of corporate social responsibility across society while contributing to the development of a national economy that delivers positive and sustainable impact," he said.

During the launch, Sheikh Mansour also honoured winners of the Impact Seal —

Platinum Tier, recognising organisations that have made outstanding contributions to sustainable impact.

Highest recognition

The Impact Seal is the UAE's highest federal recognition for corporate social responsibility and sustainability. It recognises organisations that demonstrate leading practices based on an impact index, which measures private sector performance across environmental, social and governance (ESG) standards and contributions to the sustainable development goals (SDGs).

Abu Dhabi National Energy Company (Taqa), Adnoc, DP World, The Emirates Group, Majid Al Futtaim Holding, RAK Ceramics, and Advanced Media Trading were among the recipients of the honour.

SEE ALSO P-II

IN FOCUS



FLAME TREE TRAIL

How a spectacular summer bloom has now evolved into one of Dubai's most distinctive cultural movements | P8-9